

have thought of it as a thing that merely *happened*, the end of some inevitable chain." It was unbelievable to him then, as it is to us now, that a single person could have been responsible for changing the outcome of an event watched by some fifty million people.

In real life, the 1919 World Series was fixed not by Wolfsheim, but with great skill and audacity by Arnold Rothstein, a Jewish gangster. A young lieutenant colonel in the U.S. Army named Dwight Eisenhower eagerly followed the game as the scores came in via telegram, and like everyone else, never suspected a thing. He would remark years later that the revelation of the conspiracy that had thrown the series produced a profound change in his perspective about the world; it taught him never to trust in first appearances.

Nearly a century has passed, and too many of us have not yet lost that Jazz Age naïveté. One longtime Washington columnist wrote recently that years of covering politics taught him one lesson: the legend of Washington as a ceaseless, ruthless, scheming place is simply that, a legend. The truth, he says, is that "No one can carry out complicated plans. All parties and groups are fractious and bumbling." We nod our heads in agreement. We shake our heads in disappointment.

This is a book for a world that has come to think like Nick Carraway, riding in disbelief through life on the wake of conspiracies we won't believe until we see, unable to comprehend why they happen and who makes them happen. This ignorance of how things really work is depressing to me. Because it opens us up to manipulation. It closes us off from opportunities to produce fruitful change and advance our own goals. It is time to grow up.

Nick Denton, whom you will come to know in these pages, is a kind of freethinker who has always held that the things other people are afraid to say are precisely the ones that need saying most. Peter